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and are banking on him.”

What made such a huge impact was perhaps the ease with which Modi held forth during his Dalian trip. “Entrepreneurs have a great capability to act as a unifying force in a way that even politicians can’t,” he told a packed audience at a special dinner in Dalian hosted to share his vision for Gujarat. “They can bridge the gap between societies and cultures by sharing the fruits of success as well as knowledge, labour and capital to create a universal sense of oneness, leading from nationhood to global consciousness.”

Little wonder then that Gujarat has emerged as the country’s No. 1 investment destination for 2007. According to Reserve Bank of India (RBI), Gujarat has received investment commitment worth Rs 75,000 crore in 2006-2007. In addition, early this year, the Vibrant Gujarat Investment Summit witnessed an investment commitment of Rs 4.51 lakh crore in 86 projects. According to RBI, 25 per cent of the country’s total investment is coming in Gujarat.

While statistical analogies abound, there are many pointers to the promise that Gujarat continues to hold. The maximum number of special economic zones (SEZs)—47—are coming up here. Not just that, five of India’s six multi-product SEZs are also being set up in the state. Significantly, 70 per cent of the industry majors’ focus is on infrastruc-

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ture, which gives investment a multiplier effect in terms of economic growth and job creation. Modi says, “Our accent is on ensuring that the key infrastructure is in place.” At 99 per cent, the state has the best road connectivity.

A look at the power situation shows transmission and distribution losses have been cut significantly. While the peak demand is 9,000 MW, the state has to borrow only 300 MW today in place of a 1,500 MW shortfall only a few years ago. Today industry has to face power staggering for not more than 30 days in a year. Also, the upcoming 2,200 km gas grid will ensure cheap energy supply. As H.K. Dash, vice-chairman of the Gujarat Maritime Board (GMB), says, “In five years, we have enhanced the cargo handling capacity of our ports from 70 million to over 200 million tonne. With a dozen new ports coming up, our capacity will double in four years”.

Industrialist Gautam Adani of the Adani Group says, “Modi is a marketer par excellence. He has created a level-playing field for businessmen.” With a view to attracting foreign investment, he has led innumerable business delegations abroad, projecting Gujarat as the future investment destination. Key permission procedures have been simplified while labour laws have been relaxed. It is this emphasis on creating a conducive atmosphere that has made all the difference for Gujarat.